

Briefing VI — Provence and the French Riviera

Heading South

As wonderful as Paris is, there comes a moment when it's time to leave.

We'll board the high-speed train at Gare de Lyon, settle into our seats, and watch the scenery outside our windows begin to change.

Gradually, the broad boulevards and grand buildings of Paris will give way to rolling countryside.

The light will seem a little brighter.

The sky a little bigger.

Before long, vineyards, olive groves, cypress trees, and the unmistakable landscapes of southern France will begin to appear.

We'll arrive in Aix-en-Provence just after lunchtime.

We'll stretch our legs with a walk through one of Provence's most elegant towns, enjoy an ice cream, wander its beautiful streets, and begin to notice that the rhythm of life has changed.

Then we'll make one final drive to what will become our home for the rest of the trip.

Our villa.

In many ways, I think this house becomes the final destination of our journey.

It won't just be where we sleep.

It will be where we gather for breakfast before heading out each morning.

Where the kids jump in the pool after a day of exploring.

Where we'll share dinners, tell stories, laugh about the day's adventures, and perhaps enjoy a glass of rosé as the sun begins to set.

Unlike our earlier stops, where we packed up and moved every day or two, this is where we'll finally have the chance to unpack—not just our suitcases, but ourselves.

That's intentional.

France isn't only about seeing remarkable places.

It's also about learning to enjoy unhurried time together.

Over the next week, we'll certainly visit beautiful beaches, charming coastal towns, and some unforgettable corners of the Mediterranean.

But I have a feeling that years from now, some of our favorite memories won't come from a famous landmark at all.

They'll come from an evening around the dinner table.

A quiet morning by the pool.

A game with the kids.

Or simply sitting on the terrace, watching another perfect summer day come to an end.

If Paris was about discovering one of the world's great cities...

I think the South is going to be about discovering something even simpler.

How wonderful it can be to slow down.

A Land Shaped by the Mediterranean

Over the past week, we'll have seen several very different parts of France.

The green fields of Brittany.

The windswept beaches of Normandy.

The grand boulevards of Paris.

Now we're about to discover another France entirely.

One shaped, above all else, by the Mediterranean Sea.

For thousands of years, people have been drawn to this coastline for one simple reason.

Life is easier here.

The climate is warm.

The winters are mild.

The sea provides food.

The land produces olives, grapes, herbs, and countless other crops that thrive in the sunshine.

Even the landscape seems designed for living outdoors.

As we explore over the next week, you'll notice vineyards stretching across the hillsides.

Olive trees that have stood for generations.

Tall cypress trees pointing toward the sky.

Colorful flowers spilling over stone walls.

And houses with shutters that help keep out the afternoon sun.

None of those things are accidental.

They've all been shaped by the Mediterranean climate and by generations of people adapting to it.

You'll also notice that much of life seems to happen outside.

Morning coffee on a café terrace.

Friends lingering over lunch.

Evening walks through town.

Markets spilling into the streets.

Children playing in village squares long after dinner.

The beautiful weather isn't simply something people enjoy.

It's something they've built their lives around.

Perhaps that's why this part of France has inspired so many artists over the centuries.

The extraordinary light has drawn painters for generations.

The landscapes have inspired writers.

The sea has welcomed travelers from every corner of Europe.

There's a reason so many people have dreamed of spending time here.

As we travel from town to town, I hope you'll notice that each place has its own personality.

Aix-en-Provence feels elegant and refined.

Port Grimaud is playful, with canals that have earned it the nickname "the Venice of Provence."

Saint-Tropez blends a working fishing harbor with one of the world's most famous resort towns.

Cannes carries a touch of glamour while still looking out over the same blue Mediterranean that has drawn visitors here for centuries.

They're all different.

But they're connected by the same sea.

And over the next week, I think we'll discover that the Mediterranean isn't simply something beautiful to look at.

It's the reason this entire corner of France became what it is.

The Mediterranean

Over the next week, two of the experiences I'm looking forward to most won't happen on land at all.

They'll happen out on the Mediterranean.

For most of us, it's natural to think of traveling along a coastline by road.

You drive from one town to the next.

Stop at a beach.

Visit a harbor.

Then continue on.

But for almost all of history, that's not how people experienced this part of the world.

In fact, for thousands of years, many of the places we'll visit were meant to be approached from the sea.

The Mediterranean wasn't the edge of Europe.

It was the center of it.

Long before there were coastal highways, the sea was the highway.

Greek sailors.

Roman merchants.

Fishermen.

Pilgrims.

Explorers.

Families traveling from one harbor to another.

For countless generations, people discovered this coastline from the deck of a boat, watching villages slowly appear over the horizon before sailing into sheltered ports.

In many ways, that's exactly what we'll be doing.

As we leave Port Grimaud aboard our catamaran...

As we cruise toward the Lérins Islands from Cannes...

As we drift into quiet coves for a swim...

We'll be experiencing the Mediterranean much as travelers have for thousands of years.

As you're looking back toward the shore, notice how the villages seem to gather around their harbors.

Church towers rise above the rooftops, making them easy to spot from offshore.

The buildings seem to tumble gently toward the water.

Everything faces the sea.

That's because, for most of their history, the sea wasn't something beyond the town.

It was the town's front door.

The boats we'll be on are certainly more comfortable than those used by the Greeks or Romans.

And I suspect our lunches will be much better.

But the perspective hasn't changed very much at all.

I hope we spend part of these days swimming in impossibly clear water.

Laughing together on deck.

Watching the coastline drift by.

And every once in a while, simply looking back toward land and imagining what it must have felt like to arrive here centuries ago.

There's something wonderfully timeless about seeing the Mediterranean this way.

It reminds us that this sea didn't divide civilizations.

It connected them.

And for a few unforgettable days, we'll become a very small part of that same story.

Our Riviera

Now that we've talked about the South of France, let's talk about our South of France.

Unlike the first part of our journey, where every day brought a new destination, this final week has a different rhythm.

Each morning, we'll head out from the same front door.

Each evening, we'll return to the same place.

I have a feeling that by the end of the week, the villa won't simply feel like a house we rented.

It will feel like home.

Our first afternoon gives us a wonderful introduction.

After arriving by train and settling into the house, we'll spend a little time wandering through Aix-en-Provence.

There won't be a long checklist of sights.

Instead, we'll enjoy exactly the kind of afternoon this region does so well.

Walking shaded streets.

Finding a good ice cream.

Watching life unfold around us.

Then we'll make our way home.

And that's really the point.

Throughout the week, we'll discover beautiful places, but we won't be racing from one hotel to the next.

We'll always know exactly where the day will end.

Some mornings we'll set off on the Mediterranean.

Other days we'll spend on beautiful beaches, in seaside towns, or exploring the Riviera together.

We'll stroll the canals of Port Grimaud.

Walk the streets of Saint-Tropez.

Spend time in Sainte-Maxime.

Visit Cannes.

Watch the kids fly through the ropes course.

And, just as importantly, we'll leave plenty of room for the unexpected.

Some of my favorite moments are already built into the itinerary.

Not because they're famous.

Because they're wonderfully ordinary.

A lazy morning by the pool.

A game before dinner.

Picking up groceries from a local market.

Cooking together at the house.

A pizza on the canals in Port Grimaud.

Fresh seafood overlooking the harbor.

An afternoon that stretches a little longer because nobody is in a hurry to leave.

I'm also hoping to introduce a few of you to one of my favorite traditions—playing a game of backgammon by the pool. Kate's dad, John Ferguson, who we lost last year, loved sitting down for a game with me while we shared a glass of pastis, which I like to think is the proper way to spend a summer afternoon in southern France. I'd love to keep that tradition alive with some new opponents this week.

Those aren't the moments people usually put on postcards.

But they're often the ones that stay with us.

One thing I especially appreciate about the way Kate planned this final week is that she gave us permission not to do everything.

If part of the group wants another swim while others wander through Saint-Tropez...

Perfect.

If someone would rather stay by the pool while others head into town...

Also perfect.

This isn't the kind of place where everyone has to do exactly the same thing every hour of every day.

It's the kind of place where everyone can find their own perfect afternoon before coming back together for dinner.

And I suspect those evenings may become some of our favorite memories of the trip.

We'll gather around one table again.

Share stories from the day.

Laugh about whatever unexpected adventure happened.

Watch the younger kids slowly run out of energy.

And probably start saying things like...

"Remember when we..."

Long before we've even gone home.

By the time we pack our suitcases one last time, I don't think we'll simply feel like we've visited the French Riviera.

I think we'll feel like, for one wonderful week, we got to live here together.

The Last Days

Every great trip has its own rhythm.

At the beginning, there's excitement.

Packing.

Airports.

The anticipation of finally arriving.

Then comes discovery.

New places.

New foods.

New experiences.

Before long, though, something quietly changes.

The places no longer feel unfamiliar.

The bakery starts to feel familiar.

The walk back to the villa no longer requires directions.

Favorite beaches begin to emerge.

Favorite restaurants.

Favorite memories.

And then, almost without warning, it's time to start thinking about going home.

I've always found those last few days of a trip to be a little bittersweet.

Not because I'm eager for them to end.

But because they're often the days I'm most able to appreciate where I am.

The pressure to see everything has faded.

The excitement of arrival has settled into something quieter.

Gratitude.

As we enjoy these final days together, I hope we'll leave a little room to simply notice what we've built over the past two weeks.

The conversations around the dinner table.

The inside jokes that somehow appeared out of nowhere.

The stories we'll be telling for years.

The confidence that comes from realizing France no longer feels quite so unfamiliar.

And perhaps most importantly, the time we've spent together.

One last favor before we head home.

Remember our Paris Challenge?

To notice the little things that most visitors walk right past?

I'd love for you to keep playing that game through the rest of our journey.

Notice the small moments.

The funniest thing that happens.

Your favorite meal.

A conversation you'll remember.

A place you didn't expect to love.

Or simply a moment when you looked around and thought, "I'm really glad we're here."

When we get home, I'd love each of you to send me one moment you'll never forget. It doesn't have to be the biggest or most important. Sometimes the smallest moments become the ones we remember longest.

I'm planning one final expedition briefing—not about France, but about our adventure together. I think it would be wonderful to weave everyone's stories together into one last chapter of this expedition, something our family can come back to years from now.

Long after we've forgotten exactly which day we visited which town...

Or exactly where we had our favorite meal...

I think we'll remember how it felt to share this adventure as a family.

Because in the end, that's what this trip was always about.

Not simply seeing France.

But experiencing it together.

And I can't think of a better way to bring our journey to a close.